

Smart Training

Tired of seeing your trainees dozing off at training sessions? Maybe you're going about it the wrong way. Here's presenting some radical new ways to impart training

The Advantages

Avatar-based training can pool in all the resources and experience of human trainers and deliver an identical training session every time, thereby ensuring the optimal training experience in every session—something even the most experienced trainers are not capable of achieving. Another advantage of avatar-based training is that the training module can be run at the convenience of the trainee's time, and can be viewed over and over for reinforcement. The training can also be used in large organisations, where employees are scattered across continents.

Accenture is developing various avatar-based training modules, and recently deployed one at British Telecom, the UK's largest telecommunications provider. The programme helped train 4,500 salespeople in just four weeks, as opposed to the eight weeks a traditional training program would have taken. Then, a training module developed for NASA allows the trainee to observe living and working conditions in the polar regions of Mars, with an avatar explaining various details of the conditions on-screen.

Avatars can be made to identify with the trainees, in terms of ethnicity and age—so soldiers can be trained by a military avatar, and a younger audience can have a teenage avatar. With powerful off-the-shelf graphics technology available, military and space exploration training avatars move and look a lot more realistic than ever before. However, animating an entire training module could cost anywhere between Rs 50,000 and lakhs of rupees right now. With an increased demand for these services, however, costs should fall rapidly.



Avatar-based training is touted to be the future

Imaging Shrikishna Patkar
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In most organisations, training is usually one-sided: you have a trainer teaching a skill-set the company deems important, while most participants happily dream of quitting time and martinis. Fortunately, there is a quiet revolution taking place. Companies are exploring innovative ways to make training interesting, which means value for the money they spend on training.

Avatar Training

Traditionally, we have always had human trainers teaching a class. These days, however, avatars are assuming the role of imaginary coaches, co-workers, or customers in computer-based training modules designed to teach specific skills.

An avatar is a computer-generated simulation of humans that may be photo-realistic, or a cartoon character with head-and-shoulder views that come and go as the computer-based training module runs its course.